THE BATTLE OF WALONG

THE WALONG SECTOR

The Lohit River Valley marks the eastern extreme of the Assam Himalayas. The river enters Indian territory at Rima, which lies just north of Kibithu, in a comparatively low altitude valley. The river then flows southward to Walong and Hayuliang before curving westwards to debouch into the plains of Assam. The Lohit is joined by the Dibang near Sadiya and, a little further to the west, by the Siang at Pasighat. From this point it is known as the Brahmaputra. Further downstream, the Subansiri and the Kameng add their substantial volume of water before it meets the Manas (Nyamjang Chu) after which it curves south again into Bangladesh where it goes by the name of Jamuna.

The Lohit Frontier Division, unlike Kameng at the other end of the spectrum, was an even bigger logistical nightmare. The 1950 earthquake had completely destroyed the Lohit River Valley, erasing even the existing few footpaths that connected the region to the rest of the world. Without the grassy runway that could accommodate small aircraft on the west bank of the river, it is doubtful if the Assam Rifles would have made any headway in the region.

The Mishmi and the Zekhring are the main tribes of this thinly populated region of less than 20,000 people. Fed by many rivers, this is a fertile area and agriculture is the predominant occupation.

The Digaru Mishmi, popularly known as the Taraon, are concentrated around Tezu, Hayuliang, Chaglagam and Goiliang of Lohit Frontier Division. There is a belief that the Mishmi are in fact indigenous people. This is borne out by the places of origin recited by the priests during the performance of rituals. The Nim-kwey cave is at the confluence of the Lohit and Tidding Rivers, about forty kilometres from Hayuliang and sixty-five kilometres from Tezu. It is sacred and central to their religious beliefs. They are jhum cultivators as well as adept craftsman and weavers. Their